“Could the Weinführer be early?” Léa asked, unease sweeping over her. She glanced at the corner, to check that nothing revealed the hidden hatch. Last night, they’d covered the stone entrance with the rug and placed the carpet, table and chair on top, as always.

Édouard straightened his shoulders and brushed dust off his hands. Footfalls crunched the pebbled path outside. They turned to the open doors, where the sun caught the long shadow of a person standing at the entrance. Léa’s stomach tightened with alarm as she recognized the sharp-pointed boots as the ones worn by German soldiers.

“Herr LeBlanc, are you in there?”

“Who is it?” Édouard’s voice was calm and steady.

“I’m Kommandant Abetz.” He strode into the *chai*. “You’re coming with me.”

“What, why?”

“There’s been a Resistance attack on the main cable leading from Combleux to Orléans. Partisans from Combleux destroyed it.” His eyes darted from Édouard to Léa.

“I know nothing of it,” Édouard said. “I’ve been—”

“We’ll see about that.”

“I have work to complete for Weinführer Brucker.”

“The harvest is over.” The Kommandant glanced around the *chai*. “What work?”

“My wine production has been turned into ethanol. Weinführer Brucker will collect the barrels the day after tomorrow. I have ten yet to fill.”

The Kommandant stepped forward, his dark eyes locked on Léa. “And you cannot do this work on your own?”

Léa hesitated, her voice trembling as she searched for a way to persuade him not to take Édouard. “The barrels are heavy. I can’t lift them to the spout to fill.”

The Kommandant watched her with a calculating expression that made Léa feel as small as an ant he could crush at his will. Holding in her fear, she didn’t dare look away. “Then I will send a man to help you.” His gaze flicked toward Édouard. “You have five minutes to gather your things. Instruct your wife to bring your meals to the mairie every day. I’ll be waiting for you outside.” He put his hands behind his back and strode toward the door.